



INTRODUCTION TO JINGDEZHEN PORCELAIN IN THE LATE QING DYNASTY

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During the reigns of Jiaqing and Daoguang in the Qing Dynasty, there were no government officials especially in charge of porcelain production in Imperial Factory in Jingdezhen, which, instead, was supervised by local officials. The porcelains produced by Imperial Factory during the early Jiaqing Reign brought forth no new artistic characteristics and were no better than their counterparts made during Qianlong Reign. Their modelling and decorative patterns were similar to those in Qianlong Reign, with some excellent works that included: the *Qinghua* double-handled oblate vase with inscriptions 福壽 in collection of the Palace Museum in Beijing, the Fencai covered jar decorated with patterns of landscapes and figures in collection of Shanghai Museum, and the *Qinghua* Zun with *Chi*-dragon handles, decorated with lotus scrolls pattern in collection of Provincial Antique Store of Jiangxi, etc. They were the masterpieces of that stage with high ornamental value, featured by regular modelling, delicate drawing lines, and evenly spread colours. Apart from these, the eggshell bowls, plates, cups and dishes were produced in large quantity during that stage, featured by fine and delicate decorative patterns depicting the so-called "ten scenery of Lushan Mountain, West Lake and Dongting Lake," etc. The porcelain stationery and the snuff bottles, the favourites of scholars and officials of the reigns before, were also massively produced and well welcomed. As the Imperial Factory during Daoguang Reign inherited the artistic style of their predecessors in the late Jiaqing Reign in their porcelain production, historical accounts call the porcelains produced by the Imperial Factory during the two reigns "Jia(qing)-Dao(guang) Porcelain."

In 1840, the Opium War broke out, putting the porcelain production in Jingdezhen on a downhill path. Porcelains produced by civilian or Imperial Factory were clumsy in modelling. The patterns of "*Tanhua* (No. 3 in national civil examinations) in *Success*" consisted of the designs of colourful butterflies and insects, and the patterns of fighting cocks and playful dogs became one of the artistic styles of Daoguang porcelain. Yet there were also some articles of fine artistic quality, such as the tea cup-and-saucer decorated with coral red orchid pattern, now in collection of the Jingdezhen Ceramic Museum. Round at the bottom and square on top, the cup-and-saucer carries decorative patterns of orchids and some verses and seals, demonstrating artistic originality.

Small porcelain articles made during Daoguang Reign were very delicate, represented by the cricket jar decorated with colourful patterns and the snuff bottle. And among articles for daily use, the *Guangzi* bowl was the most famous. Their artistic attainment was widely acknowledged by the later generations. Included in this book is a photo of a *Qinghua* decorated with a scene of

imperial kiln, depicting with celadon pigment the panoramic view of the booming porcelain production in the Imperial Factory in Jingdezhen. The porcelain table-surface was not only a representative of fine porcelains made during Daoguang Reign, but also provides valuable information to the research on the Imperial Factory in Jingdezhen in the Qing Dynasty.

Original methods were also adopted by civil kilns in decorating porcelains in an integrated fashion. An example was the bean celadon vase decorated with landscape and figure pattern in tricolour of high-temperature and light reddish brown, now in collection of Wuyuan County Museum of Jiangxi Province. With its shoulders decorated with *Tieguni* glazed (lightless black glazed) banana leaf and *Ruyi* pattern and with double lion-masked ring-handles, the vase was graceful in shape and luxuriant in decorations and indeed a piece of fine work of art of civil kilns.

A peasant uprising called the Taiping Heavenly Kingdom broke out in the first year of the Xianfeng Reign, dealing another blow at the rule of the Qing government. The Imperial Factory, which produced porcelain for the court, stopped production in the fifth year of Xianfeng Reign (AD 1855). According to *The Qing Archives* (《清檔》), only 2,100 pieces of porcelain were produced by the Imperial Factory during the Xianfeng Reign. And in 1861, the English-French Allied Forces burned down the imperial garden Yuanmingyuan and pillaged and destroyed large quantities of Chinese national treasures. That explains why only a few porcelain works made during the Xianfeng Reign were passed on to the later generations. Among them were the articles in the *Fencai* and the gold colour with decorative patterns of the Eight Treasures, the curios and antiques, the figure and landscape, and the flower and butterfly and those in the tea dust glazed porcelain, which were of high artistic attainment. One representative was the blue glazed and gilt three-gourd vase decorated with flower pattern, which was in collection of the Shanghai Museum.

In the fifth year of Tongzhi Reign (AD 1866), Li Hongzhang, premier of the central government at that time, collected 130,000 taels of silver and ordered Cai Jinqing, a customs official of Jiujiang, Jiangxi Province, to rebuild 72 porcelain workshops on the original sites of Imperial Factory at Zhushan, Jingdezhen. In the seventh year of Tongzhi Reign (AD 1868), the imperial court sent Jiangxi governor Jing Fu to oversee the production of 120 barrels of, or 7,294 pieces of porcelains for the wedding of the Emperor, most of the porcelains with Fencai decoration on yellow ground. One example was the *Fencai* large plate on yellow ground, decorated with the pattern of the *Fencai* children at play on yellow ground